KEY INDICES

A STATUS REPORT

The tribal population is minuscule and public spend on bettering their lot has risen over the years, so why are they at the bottom on almost all indicators?

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The tribes of India constitute a numerically small minority, just about 9 per cent of the total population. But their expanse is vast, and their cultural imprint on Indianness way deeper than the rest—with many of them seen as descendants of the subcontinent's original inhabitants. Spread over the length and breadth of the landmass, mostly in forested and mountainous country, they are a heterogeneous set, varying greatly in language, culture, means of primary livelihood and state of development.

Nearly 80 per cent of them are concentrated in nine states—Maharashtra, Madhya Pradesh, Chhattisgarh, Gujarat, Rajasthan, Jharkhand, West Bengal, Odisha and Andhra Pradesh. About 12 per cent live in the northeastern states, five per cent in the south and three per cent in the northern region. Of the 700-plus recognised tribes, only two have more than 10 million population and 30 more than 500,000.

When India adopted its Constitution in 1950, the communities identified and enumerated as tribes by the British government were rechristened Scheduled Tribes (ST). No criteria were defined for the recognition of the STs. Later, the Lokur Committee of 1961-62 recommended five criteria for their identification that

TOP 10 TRIBAL GROUPS

Around 30 tribes in India have more than 500,000 population; only two have over 10 million population



1. BHIL

12,689,952 (12.1%)

Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh, Chhattisgarh, Gujarat, Maharashtra, Andhra Pradesh, Karnataka

2. GOND

10,859,422 (10.4%)

Bihar, West Bengal, Jharkhand, Odisha, Chhattisgarh, Madhya Pradesh, Gujarat, Andhra Pradesh, Karnataka





3. SANTHAL

5,838,016 (5.6%)

Bihar, Tripura, West Bengal, Odisha, Jharkhand